

%@^\$%\$# phone!

YES, THAT'S A CURSE WORD and no, I'm not censoring it because I'm a prude. I want you to imagine your abuse of choice in that slot. Why? Because we've all said it, at some point or another. Whether you're using a cheap Android One phone or the costs-more-than-a-bike iPhone, these things just seem to frustrate us at some time or the other.

I imagine you've said this when your phone is unresponsive because WhatsApp decided to run a backup just when your crush messaged you. Maybe you've said it when your phone auto-in-corrects everything you type because it just refuses to learn Hinglish, or your family's names. Or, maybe, when you're in a movie theatre and have forgotten to turn your stupid iPhone XS to silent, your sister sends you 47 pictures all at once! Since even the iPhone cannot recognise your super embarrassed face in the dark, and the darn swiping action to unlock is a hit and miss at times, you turn red-faced as your phone makes this almost metronome-like series of pings for each picture received, at full volume, in the middle of Bohemian Rhapsody! True story that.

As much as we love our phone, and spend more time with it than we do with actual people, it's not a "smart" phone. Yes brands will claim AI at various levels, and spend millions in ads trying to convince you that they have the next best thing... but it's all crap. While all of them will claim brilliance, none of them are actually delivering any. Innovation in this field has plateaued, and it's just a spec war – with more of the same thing being added on to give you the feeling of innovation.

Sure, Samsung or LG will come up with something ridiculous like 600+ ppi screens with 8K resolutions, or maybe foldable displays, or some other gimmick that is designed to make you go "Wow!". Or rather, to make your neighbour go "Wow!!!" and turn green with envy when you splash out a lakh and a half for a phone that is the current reigning champion, but will be surpassed in a few months at most, often by the same manufacturer!

At the end of the day, what a phone boils down to is a touch interface device that has a screen, can click pictures, has pretty good con-

nectivity to the internet, runs apps and games that you don't really need, ruins your ability to socialise, and has a battery that always runs out of juice just when you need it most.

Add in 3 cameras or 20, resolutions of 720p or 8K, memory of 3GB or 12GB... it all really has become exactly what the desktop market was 15 years ago. Stagnant. Sure we went from CRTs to LEDs, or two button ball mice to laser precision fragging weapons, but in the end the desktop was still just a PC. That's exactly what the phone has become too... a PCD (personal computing device). Specs may go up and down, but a 10k Android phone can still accomplish all the same tasks as the 1.44 lakh XS MAX. Sure, the latter feels nicer and will do things faster and better, but that's no different from some of us having lowly entry-level GPUs playing games at 720p with all the bells and whistles turned off, while others spend more on just their GPU than the first group has spent on their last 2 PCs combined!

What we need is a game changer. Not just marketing jargon. An actual one.

VR promises to be that, and AI and VR together can certainly accomplish that, while big data will power it all. Yes, big data, which is just another way of saying your data, and my data, and everyone's data all being number crunched to arrive at some pretty amazing insights about us. Eerily accurate ones at that!

Forget about Tim Cook harping on about privacy, he's just protecting his company's interests and his business model, as are all the rest who gather your data. The privacy war was lost a long, long time ago, and you gave it up willingly when you logged on to the Internet. You can't disconnect and live like a hermit anymore, and you don't want to. So stop pretending like you're a victim and embrace your Stockholm syndrome with tech.

Instead, I'd rather focus on the future and be excited about the fact that very soon (in as little as 5 years from now, I think) I won't have to suffer "smartphones" the way I do now. It will take just one real innovation to kill the smartphone (at least the current form), and I for one cannot wait for it to arrive. What about you? What do you think that innovation will be? 



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